

A PRIVATE CARTA PROPOSAL FOR JESSE GAUTHIER

Vietnam, three rhythms.

Hanoi's layered history, Hoi An's lantern-lit calm, and Saigon's full-volume food culture.

13 nights in Vietnam · Two travelers · 2028 concept priced against Feb 20 to Mar 6, 2027

THE IDEA

A first trip that feels specific, not overfilled.

I built this around the things you actually named: food, art, history, cultural depth, and a pace that leaves room to notice where you are.

The route moves north to south. Four nights in Hanoi establish the historical frame. Four nights in Hoi An slow the trip down. Five nights in Ho Chi Minh City let the food and contemporary energy land without turning every day into a checklist.

HANOI — ● HOI AN — ● SAIGON

WHAT THIS PROPOSAL ASSUMES

Travelers: Jesse and girlfriend

Starting point: IAD, selected over DCA because long-haul pricing and one-ticket options are materially stronger

Style: Value-conscious luxury, mostly strong 4-star hotels with opportunistic 5-star upgrades

Pace: Moderate, with one anchor activity per half day and protected free time

Pricing: Exact 2027 shopping snapshots used as a same-season planning proxy for a 2028 trip

THE ROUTE

Three cities. One clear arc.

Imperial and colonial layers in the north. Merchant history and craft in the center. Modern Vietnamese ambition in the south.

Why not add more?

Hue, Ha Long Bay, and the Mekong all merit time, but adding them to this length would trade depth for transit. I would rather give you a richer first trip and leave a reason to return.

01 Hanoi · 4 nights

02 Hoi An · 4 nights

03 Ho Chi Minh City · 5 nights

Food is not an add-on. It is the route.

North · restraint

Phở bò, bún chả, chả cá, bánh cuốn, egg coffee.

Clear broths, smoke, herbs, dill, and precise seasoning. Hanoi gets one guided tasting walk, one early noodle breakfast, one specialty fish dinner, and one polished northern meal.

Center · texture

Cao lầu, mì Quảng, white rose, cơm gà, bánh mì.

Hoi An's trading-port history lives in its noodles and dumplings. The plan includes a market-to-table cooking morning, family-run specialists, and one relaxed regional dinner.

South · abundance

Cơm tấm, bánh xèo, hủ tiếu, ốc, bò lá lốt.

Saigon is the deepest food chapter: breakfast noodles, market streets, a guided evening tasting route, neighborhood seafood, and one contemporary Vietnamese dinner.

The dining rule: reserve only the meals that benefit from certainty. Street stalls, noodle shops, and market stops stay flexible and are reconfirmed close to travel. No restaurant below is represented as booked.

Food research checked July 20, 2026 against Vietnam Tourism, the 2026 MICHELIN Guide, current restaurant pages, and recent local reporting. Hours, closures, hygiene conditions, and menus must be reconfirmed before the 2028 trip.

Six anchors, four nights.

STOP	ORDER	BEST MOMENT	PLANNING STATUS
Phở Gia Truyền	Rare beef or brisket phở in the northern style	Early breakfast before sightseeing	MICHELIN-listed; queue, go early
Bún Chả Hương Liên	Charcoal pork, patties, noodles, herbs	Casual lunch	Guided or independent walk-in
Chả Cá Thăng Long	Turmeric fish with dill, scallions, peanuts	Destination dinner	2026 MICHELIN Bib Gourmand; prioritize
Café Giảng	Cà phê trứng, Hanoi's egg coffee	Afternoon reset	Walk-in; verify original location
Tầm Vị	Northern home-style shared plates	One polished dinner	Reservation priority; recheck 2028 status
Chè 95	Seasonal chè and sweet soups	Post-dinner dessert walk	Flexible neighborhood stop

Guide brief: prioritize family-run specialists, explain how northern seasoning differs from the center and south, and substitute a verified current stop if quality or hygiene has slipped.

The dishes that belong here.

STOP	ORDER	BEST MOMENT	PLANNING STATUS
Cao Lầu Thanh	Cao lầu with char siu pork, herbs, crisp rice cracker	Fast first lunch	Vietnam Tourism-listed; walk-in
White Rose Restaurant	Bánh bao bánh vạc, the town's signature dumplings	Focused snack or light lunch	Family specialist; verify hours
Cơm Gà Bà Buội	Hoi An chicken rice with herbs and papaya	Casual lunch	Popular walk-in; expect a wait
Mì Quảng Di Hát	Turmeric noodles, herbs, peanuts, rice cracker	Market-day breakfast or lunch	Vietnam Tourism-listed; walk-in
Morning Glory Original	Regional standards and shared plates	Relaxed dinner	Reservation priority
Madam Khánh	Bánh mì with pâté, pickles, herbs, chile	Flexible snack	Queue; take away if busy

Cooking morning: market visit plus a small class with hands-on preparation, not a large demonstration-only tour. Flag heat tolerance and allergies before booking.

Street-level depth, one serious table.

STOP	ORDER	BEST MOMENT	PLANNING STATUS
Cơm Tấm Ba Ghiền	Broken rice, oversized grilled pork chop, egg	Early lunch	MICHELIN Bib Gourmand; queue
Bánh Xèo 46A	Crisp turmeric pancake with pork, shrimp, herbs	Casual dinner	MICHELIN Bib Gourmand; walk-in
Phở Minh	Southern phở with herbs and a fuller broth	Breakfast comparison with Hanoi	MICHELIN Bib Gourmand; go early
Ốc Đào	Snails, clams, crab, garlic and tamarind sauces	Guided evening crawl	Neighborhood specialist; guide-led
Cô Liêng	Bò lá lốt rolled with herbs and rice paper	Street-food lunch	Vietnam Tourism-listed; verify location
Ănăn Saigon	Contemporary Vietnamese tasting or à la carte	Trip-closing dinner	MICHELIN-starred; reservation priority

Tasting-route rule: use a private car or driver-guided route, cap the evening at four food stops plus one drink, and avoid repeating dishes already covered in Hanoi or Hoi An.

BIDV
CHAPTER ONE · FOUR NIGHTS

Hanoi

A city of courtyards, coffee, wartime memory, noodle smoke, and elegant contradictions.



HANOI PLAN

History first. Food always.

DAY 2 **Arrival and reset.** Private airport transfer, quiet check-in, then a short Hoan Kiem orientation walk only if energy allows.

DAY 3 **Old Quarter in context.** Small-group or private walking food tour, Hoan Kiem Lake, St. Joseph's Cathedral, and a café stop for egg coffee.

DAY 4 **Ideas and memory.** Temple of Literature, Hoa Lo Prison Relic, Vietnamese Women's Museum, then an unstructured evening.

DAY 5 **Art and living culture.** Vietnam National Fine Arts Museum, a focused craft or architecture walk, then a final Hanoi dinner.

FOOD SHORTLIST

Bun Cha Huong Lien · charcoal pork and noodles

Cha Ca Thang Long · turmeric fish at the table

Gia Truyen Bat Dan · classic pho, go early

Pizza 4P's Trang Tien · a useful modern break

Tam Vi · polished northern home cooking

I would book one destination dinner and keep the rest flexible enough to follow a local guide's best current call.

Three good versions of value.

Hanoi Fiesta Grand Hotel & Spa **\$74**

4-star · 4.9/5

Best pure value. Central, compact, and well reviewed. Choose this if most of the luxury should happen outside the room.

Displayed total: \$296 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Hanoi Tirant Hotel **\$102**

4-star · 4.6/5

My balanced pick. Old Quarter location, pool and spa, and enough polish without paying for a resort experience in a city stay.

Displayed total: \$408 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Lotte Hotel Hanoi **\$165**

5-star · 4.7/5

The opportunistic upgrade. Better facilities and skyline views, though less atmospheric than the Old Quarter.

Displayed total: \$660 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Also checked: Meliá Hanoi \$168/night, Pullman Hanoi \$98/night, Hilton Garden Inn Hanoi \$101/night. Rates shown by Google Hotels on July 19, 2026 for two adults.

CHAPTER TWO · FOUR NIGHTS

Hoi An

Merchant houses, regional cooking, riverside evenings, and enough quiet to make the middle of the trip feel like a pause.



HOI AN PLAN

Craft, ruins, then room to breathe.

DAY 6 **Fly south.** Morning flight Hanoi to Da Nang, private transfer to Hoi An, then an easy first loop through the Ancient Town.

DAY 7 **My Son, before the buses.** Early private guide to the Cham sanctuary, return for a long lunch, then free evening by the river.

DAY 8 **Market to table.** Morning market and hands-on cooking experience, followed by an open afternoon for a pool, tailor, spa, or café.

DAY 9 **Choose your pace.** Countryside cycling and Tra Que gardens, or a completely unscheduled day with dinner at a chef-led local restaurant.

FOOD SHORTLIST

Morning Glory Original · regional standards

Madam Khanh · bánh mì

Com Linh · central Vietnamese comfort food

Mango Mango · riverfront modern Vietnamese

Nữ Eatery · small plates near the Japanese Bridge

Hoi An is where I would leave the most white space. Its best moments are often the ones between bookings.

Resort calm without resort pricing.

Little Oasis Eco Friendly Hotel & Spa

\$76

5-star · 4.9/5

The deal hunter's pick. Full resort amenities at a rate that leaves room for experiences and better meals.

Displayed total: \$304 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

La Siesta Hoi An Resort & Spa

\$111

5-star · 4.8/5

My recommendation. Strong service record, real resort breathing room, and a comfortable base between Old Town and a slower day.

Displayed total: \$444 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Hoi An Historic Hotel

\$106

4-star · 4.5/5

Best for walkability. A more central, garden-style stay when being near the Ancient Town matters more than a secluded resort mood.

Displayed total: \$424 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Also checked: Silkotel Hoi An \$45/night, Hoi An Silk Marina Resort & Spa \$101/night, Hoi An Odyssey Hotel \$56/night. Rates shown by Google Hotels on July 19, 2026 for two adults.

CHAPTER THREE · FIVE NIGHTS

Ho Chi Minh City

Fast, layered, generous, and best understood through the table.



SAIGON PLAN

The city's past, then its appetite.

DAY 10 **Arrive and look up.** Fly Da Nang to Ho Chi Minh City, settle in, then a rooftop drink and unfussy dinner.

DAY 11 **The twentieth century.** Reunification Palace and War Remnants Museum with a guide who can add context rather than slogans.

DAY 12 **Chợ Lớn and street food.** Chinatown temples, markets, traditional medicine streets, then an evening tasting route by car or vintage Vespa.

DAY 13 **Art and design.** Fine Arts Museum, contemporary gallery stops, independent boutiques, and a chef-led dinner.

DAY 14 **One open day.** Optional early Cu Chi visit, a Mekong day, or stay in the city for coffee, spa, and last-minute shopping.

DAY 15 **Homeward.** Day room or late checkout if available, fly Saigon to Hanoi, then connect to the 11:50 PM international departure.

FOOD SHORTLIST

Ốc Đào · snails and seafood

Cơm Tấm Ba Ghiền · broken rice and grilled pork

Bếp Mẹ Ỉn · accessible southern classics

Anan Saigon · contemporary Vietnamese tasting

Hum · polished vegetarian Vietnamese

The Workshop · specialty coffee break

Five nights, three price points.

T-Ritz Saigon Hotel & Apartment

\$96

4-star · 4.9/5

Best value. Modern, highly reviewed, and easy to justify if the city itself is the main event.

Displayed total: \$480 for 5 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Mai House Saigon Hotel

\$144

5-star · 4.8/5

My recommendation. It feels like a proper finish to the trip without moving into trophy-hotel pricing.

Displayed total: \$720 for 5 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

La Siesta Premium Saigon

\$181

5-star · 4.9/5

The splurge. Excellent guest scores, a strong central location, and a more boutique version of five-star service.

Displayed total: \$905 for 5 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Also checked: Winsuites Saigon \$104/night, The Odys Boutique Hotel \$59/night, Oakwood Hotel & Apartments Saigon \$63/night. Rates shown by Google Hotels on July 19, 2026 for two adults.

IAD wins this one.

ROUTING	SCHEDULE	STOPS	LIVE FARE
Outbound IAD to HAN Korean Air / Delta	Feb 20, 11:50 AM Arrive Feb 21, 9:45 PM 21h 55m	1 stop 1h 05m at ICN	\$1,306 per adult Round trip economy package
Return HAN to IAD Asiana / Korean Air	Mar 6, 11:50 PM Arrive Mar 7, 9:50 AM 22h 00m	1 stop 4h 30m at ICN	\$2,612 for two Taxes and required fees included

DCA would add a positioning segment and more ways for the trip to break. For a transpacific itinerary, the simpler IAD origin is worth protecting.

This is a shopping snapshot, not a held reservation. Baggage and advance seat selection can add cost.

PREMIUM ECONOMY REFERENCE

\$2,204 per adult was the lowest display, but the itinerary mixed cabins and the top return required a Tokyo NRT to HND airport transfer. I would not recommend it as shown.

PLANNING BUDGET · TWO ADULTS

A credible 2028 working range.

COMPONENT	BASIS	WORKING AMOUNT
International flights	Live 2027 IAD-HAN round trip snapshot	\$2,612
Hotels	Hanoi Tirant + La Siesta Hoi An + Mai House Saigon	\$1,572 displayed \$1,800 planning allowance with taxes/fees
Three domestic flights	HAN-DAD, DAD-SGN, SGN-HAN with checked bags	\$360 to \$520
Private transfers	Airport and intercity ground transfers	\$280 to \$420
Guides and experiences	Food tours, My Son, museums, cooking, art	\$650 to \$950
Meals and drinks	Street-food depth, regional specialists, a private tasting route, and 3 reservation dinners	\$1,100 to \$1,500
Planning flex	2028 repricing, gratuities, minor changes	\$700 to \$950

COMFORTABLE WORKING TOTAL

\$7,500 to \$8,800

FOR TWO, BEFORE ADVISOR FEES AND INSURANCE

The biggest controllable lever is the long-haul cabin. A clean premium economy itinerary will likely push the total above this range once 2028 schedules open.

PRACTICAL NOTES

What I would lock first.

The route is sound. The next decision is not another city. It is the hotel mix and how much comfort you want to buy on the long-haul flight.

1. Choose the hotel level in each city. My balanced combination is Hanoi Tirant, La Siesta Hoi An, and Mai House Saigon.

2. Re-shop air when 2028 opens. I would prioritize one-stop IAD service through Seoul, Tokyo, or Taipei and reject any airport-change connection.

3. Hold the food anchors first. A strong Hanoi food guide, Hoi An market-to-table cooking morning, Saigon tasting route, and the three reservation dinners matter more than filling every evening.

POWER AND CONNECTIVITY

Vietnam uses 220V power. Outlets commonly accept Type A, C, and sometimes F plugs. Most phones and laptops are dual voltage, but check hair tools before packing.

Bring one compact universal adapter per traveler and keep a charging brick in your carry-on. An eSIM plus hotel Wi-Fi is the simplest setup.

ENTRY AND HEALTH

Passport validity and Vietnam e-visa rules must be reconfirmed against official sources before ticketing. I would also review travel insurance, routine vaccines, and current health guidance at booking time.

MY RECOMMENDATION

Keep the route.
Spend selectively.

Use four-star value in Hanoi, take the resort upgrade in Hoi An, and finish with a real five-star stay in Saigon.

That puts the money where it changes the feeling of the trip, while preserving enough budget for the food, guides, and private transfers that make Vietnam easier to experience well.

Recommended hotel combination

Hanoi Tirant Hotel · La Siesta Hoi An Resort & Spa · Mai House Saigon Hotel

Recommended air strategy

One-stop from IAD, economy now as the planning floor, then re-shop a clean premium economy option when 2028 inventory opens.

PREPARED FOR JESSE GAUTHIER

Ready when you are.

This proposal is the planning frame, not a held booking. Once the hotel mix and cabin preference are confirmed, I can turn it into the trip.

Gabe · Carta Travel

gabe@travelbycarta.com · +1 323 854 1678

Sources: Google Flights and Google Hotels live shopping snapshots, Vietnam Tourism, the 2026 MICHELIN Guide, current restaurant and hotel pages, UNESCO, and recent local reporting. All prices in USD and subject to change until booked.